Opposition Coordination in Authoritarian Regimes
Evidence from Mexico's 1988 Election*

Adrián Lucardi
Department of Political Science
ITAM
adrian.lucardi@itam.mx

Arturo Romero
Department of Political Science
ITAM
arturo.romero@itam.mx

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Opposition parties in authoritarian regimes are supposed to do better when they agree to coordinate behind a common candidate. Yet elite-level coordination decisions are typically made behind closed doors, and thus difficult to document and measure. Moreover, coordination may affect electoral results through two alternative, though not mutually exclusive, channels: (a) by affecting how voters are *aggregated*; and/or (b) by *increasing* the vote share of the parties presenting a common candidate. We exploit novel candidate nomination data from Mexico's 1988 election, in which the ruling Institutional Revolutionary Party (PRI) faced its first serious electoral challenge in decades. The main opposition candidate was supported by four parties that ran on common candidates in some single-member districts (SMDs) but not in others, in effect varying the degree of coordination in the legislative election. Moreover, even when parties agree on a common candidate, results are reported separately by party, and the list of candidates changed no less than eight times between the date of first publication and the election. We document how coordination increased substantially over the curse of the campaign period and that both mechanisms mattered: parties that nominated a common candidate experienced a 3 percentage point-bump in their vote share, aggregating votes for multiple parties switched 18 out of 300 SMDs.

Keywords: electoral coordination – authoritarian regimes – opposition – Mexico

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Adrián: We have two ideas on how to frame the paper: one focused on coordination in authoritarian regimes; the other on how Mexico's 1988 election illuminates an oft overlooked feature of elections in authoritarian regimes. These are mutually incompatible (though we can put both pieces of text below in different parts of the paper). Getting good feedback on how to frame the paper is the most useful things we can get from the conference.

Framing #1: Coordination in authoritarian regimes

Among the least studied elements in electoral autocrats' toolkit is their capacity to enhancing electoral coordination among pro-government forces, and denying it to their opponents. Unlike electoral fraud and the (selective or massive) use of repression to ensure electoral victory, winning thanks to superior coordination –or from one's opponents' failure to do so– is common in both democracies and electoral autocracies, though of course the specific means to achieve such (lack of) coordination may of course differ.

Yet even in democracies, coordination is hard to observe and measure because... This is especially the case for *elite* coordination, whereby...

Framing #2: The 1988 election

The 1988 election is widely recognized as a watershed in Mexican political history. Cuauhtémoc Cárdenas, son of a beloved PRI presidents and a former prominent *priáista* himself, launched the first major electoral challenge against the ruling party since 1952 (Langston 2002). Complaints of electoral irregularities began surfacing early on election day, and by that night the electoral authority announced that the counting system had "broken down." Several days later, official results showed the PRI candidate ahead of Cárdenas, 50.4% to 31.1%.[1] Cárdenas and his supporters immediately cried foul –indeed, both anecdotal and systematic (Cantú 2019) evidence show substantial evidence of fraud– and refused to recognize the results. The PRI candidate assumed office but, lacking the supermajority needed to pass constitutional reforms, was forced to work with the right-

[1]The third-placed candidate got 17.1%, and the rest went to a couple of minor candidates.

wing opposition party to pass major reforms (Molinar Horcasitas and Weldon 1990; Bruhn 1997; Castañeda 1998 [2001]; Cantú 2019). Going forward, Mexican politics became more competitive and contentious, as the PRI could no longer take its voters for granted (Eisenstadt 2004; Magaloni 2006). Though the path that leads from 1988 to 2000 –in which the PRI eventually relinquished the presidency– is far from linear (Garrido de Sierra 2019), the 2000 defeat would had hardly been possible outside the more open political system that prevailed through the 1990s, which in turn were due to the 1988 electoral shock.

In this paper we study a relatively unknown aspect of the 1988 election: how the four parties that backed Cárdenas in the presidential election managed to coordinate –or failed to do so– across Mexico's 300 single-member districts (SMDs). While in 1979-1985 the PRI had captured ≥ 292 (97%) of such districts, in 1988 it lost 28 (9.3%) to Cárdenas' National Democratic Front (FDN, after its Spanish initials) and 38 (12.7%) to the National Action Party (PAN), the right-wing opposition. Pre-electoral coordination, in the form of party elites agreeing to nominate a common candidate in a SMD, played a key role in this process. On the one hand, had Cárdenas's supporters failed to nominate a common candidate at all, they would only have captured 10 SMD seats.[2] Furthermore, the degree of coordination increased over time: according to the list of candidates published on April 7th, the FDN would have obtained just 21 seats; a series of candidate replacements in the upcoming months brought this number up to 28. On the other hand, internecine rivalries among Cárdenas's supporters (Bruhn 1997, ch. 4) put a limit on the FDN's ability to coordinate. This was costly: had the coalition nominated a common candidate on all districts –especially in Mexico City and the state of Mexico, two large states that Cárdenas won handily– it would have captured another 64 SMDs, more than a fifth of the Chamber of Deputies.[3]

[2]Of the 18 districts the FDN would have lost, 16 would have gone to the PRI and 2 to the PAN.

[3]Of these 64, 53 would have come from the PRI and 11 from the PAN. Still, a majority clause introduced just before the election meant that as the party with most SMD seats, the PRI would receive a minimum of 251 seats in the 500-member chamber (Molinar Horcasitas and Weldon 2001).

Even when coordination does take place, documenting and measuring it is far from straightforward. Suppose the PRI loses a district by 48 to 40 points, with the other 12 going to another opposition party. This could be the product of successful coordination, if a large swathe of supporters of the third-placed party deserted it in order to beat the PRI; or it could mean that 48% of the voters had the most-voted party as their first preference, in which case there was no coordination at all. Intermediate outcomes where some voters coordinate and others don't are of course possible, but the bottom line is that documenting coordination requires either (i) highly disaggregated data on the distribution of electoral support before the election.

Our focus is on *elite*-level coordination, and to identify and measure it we exploit an idiosyncratic feature of Mexico's electoral rules, the so-called *common candidacies*. Cárdenas' presidential bid was backed by a coalition of four parties, the FDN. In the concurrent House and Senate elections, in contrast, these parties could –and often did– present separate candidates. However, the electoral rules allowed two or more parties to present the same candidate in a single-member district, in which case their votes would add up when distributing SMD seats but *not* when computing seats in the proportional representation tier. If for example the PFCRN and the PPS nominated the same candidate C in district d, voters could chose between voting for candidate C through the PFCRN, C_{PFCRN}, and the same candidate for the PPS, C_{PPS}. When electing the representative from district d, these votes would add up; when allocating seats on the proportional representation tier, on the other hand, PFCRN and PPS votes would be treated separately. Furthermore, the list of candidates was not fixed: between April 7th, when the full list of candidates was first published in Mexico's official newspaper, and July 11th,[4] there were no less than *nine* instances of candidate replacements. While some of these reflected deaths, health issues and other idiosyncratic reasons, the fact that (a) they are concentrated in the majoritarian tier –the only one where coordination made sense–; that (b) they were especially frequent among FDN parties (see Figure 1(a)); and that (c) the number of

[4]That is, five days *after* the election, which took place in July 6th.

FDN candidates per district decreased monotonically with each round of replacements (Figure 1(b)) suggests that a coordination motive was dominant.

We contribute to the literature in three ways. To begin with, we credibly document an instance of *elite* coordination in an *authoritarian* setting. Lab experiments (Forsythe et al. 1993), individual-level survey data (Gandhi and Ong 2019; Plutowski, Weitz-Shapiro and Winters 2021; Castro Cornejo 2022) and primary election results (Lucardi, Vallejo and Feierherd forthcoming) can help pinpoint coordination among voters, but even in democracies direct evidence of elite-level coordination is hard to come by as pre-electoral agreements are typically decided behind closed doors. Granzier, Pons and Tricaud (2023) show that French parties use first-round ranks to coordinate when multiple parties from the same family face a common adversary in the runoff. In contrast to them, we measure coordination before the results are known (see also Blais and Indridason 2007), but also show whether coordination affected electoral performance.

Opposition parties in authoritarian regimes are more likely to form a pre-electoral coalition when either structural conditions (e.g., party age, private-sector financing) or short-term conditions (economic growth) are favorable (Wahman 2011; Arriola 2013; Gandhi and Reuter 2013), but these are mostly cross-country studies that compare wildly dissimilar polities. By comparing multiple districts during the same election we keep many of these factors constant, focusing on variation between districts instead. In this regard our paper is more similar to Wahman's (2014), who studies district-level coordination in five African countries, and Spoon and Pulido Gómez's (2017), who examine Mexican legislative elections during 2009-2015. The former includes mostly authoritarian cases, but measures coordination in term of vote distribution rather than candidate nomination. The latter studies candidate nominations in Mexico but already under democracy, when there was substantial information –from polls and past electoral results– about parties' electoral strengths.

We also examine the *effect* of coordination on electoral outcomes. Opposition coalitions likely make authoritarian elections more competitive and increase the odds of the ruling party losing the election (Howard and Roessler 2006; Donno 2013), but this raises an endogeneity problem. Using

structural equation modeling to study Mexico's common candidacies after the transition to democracy –albeit sometimes in a setting where the PRI continued to dominate local politics–, Frey, López-Moctezuma and Montero (2023) and Montero (2025) show that pre-electoral coalitions increased its partners' chance of winning and sometimes their vote share as well, though they pay less attention to why parties nominated common candidates in some districts but not others. Hortala-Vallve, Meriläinen and Tukiainen (2024) do study both the origins and consequences of pre-electoral coalitions but in an advanced democracy (Finland) in which which seats are allocated by open-list proportional representation rather than in single-member districts, where coordination arguably makes more of a difference (Duverger 1951 [1967]; Cox 1997).

Theoretical framework

Electoral coordination. Electoral coordination is anchored in what Duverger (1951 [1967]) dubbed the "psychological" effect of electoral systems. When the "mechanics" of an electoral rule make it highly unlikely that their preferred candidate or party will get into office, both voters and political elites have an incentive to abandon it in favor of a less preferred alternative that nonetheless has a higher chance of winning. In particular, in plurality or first-past-the-post (FPTP) systems like the one used to elect Mexico's 300 SMD deputies in 1988, third- and lower-placed candidates have little chance of winning, and thus they should be abandoned in favor of the first-placed alternative (by those who prefer it to the second-placed one) or the second-placed one (by those who prefer it to the top-ranked one). To put it differently, in single-member districts with plurality rule there are only two viable choices, the top-ranked party and the runner-up; rational voters and elites that only care about winning should only vote for whichever of these they like more (or dislike less; Cox 1997).

Yet while the overall idea is intuitive and politicians, party elites and (some) voters are aware of it, in practice coordination requires that some assumptions be met. Deriving Duverger's propositions from a coordination game, Cox (1997, ch. 4) showed that in a SMD with plurality rule, an equilibrium

in which only the top two parties receive a meaningful number of votes requires that (a) small-party supporters are not indifferent between the top-two placed options; (b) parties and voters seek to maximize their seat share in the current election (rather than sometime in the future); (c) there is no obvious winner; and (d) "*the identity of the leading and trailing candidates are common knowledge*."

In the 1988 Mexican election we analyze in this paper, only assumption (b) is relatively straightforward. Regarding (a), voters who disliked the government faced a choice between the PAN on the right –which wanted cleaner elections but broadly supported the administration's economic policies (Magaloni 2006)– or Cárdenas's FDN on the left –which criticized the lack of democracy and electoral manipulation but wanted to return to the economic policies of the 1960s and 1970s. And as the ruling party, the PRI could use both carrots (Arriola, DeVaro and Meng 2017) and sticks to increase the cost of nominating a common candidate. As for assumption (c), the PRI received at least 60% of the vote in 37% of districts; even if that reflected a substantial degree of electoral manipulation, the point is that even perfect coordination on the part of all opposition parties would not have prevented a government victory. Finally, while it was safe to assume that the PRI would finish either first or second –the PRI came in third in just 4 districts–, there was little information on which opposition party was best positioned to defeat it. Even in democracies, good-quality surveys are too costly to carry out in (relatively) small territorial units like single-member districts (Fredén, Rheault and Indridason 2022). The newspaper *La Jornada* did carry out a large survey that predicts the actual results remarkably well (see Figure A1), but it only reported presidential voting intentions at the state rather than the SMD level. The fact that (i) the 1988 election was going to be much more competitive than usual; and (ii) the degree of electoral manipulation could vary substantially between districts (Cantú 2019) complicated matters even further.

Explaining coordination. Nonetheless, opposition parties were not completely in the dark either. While the *La Jornada* survey mentioned above was released shortly before the election, FDN may well have had their own sources of information. As the governor of Michoacán until 1986, Cárdenas

had a strong network of supporters there, and many other FDN leaders were also former *priístas* with good knowledge of their local environment.

Knowing that the PRI could be defeated is only a necessary condition for coordinating, however. Coordination games have multiple equilibria, and the relevant players are not indifferent between these (Blais and Indridason 2007). For the sake of argument, suppose the PPS and the PFCRN are considering whether to nominate a common candidate in a district where the PRI seems beatable: while both parties (and their would-be candidates) may prefer to beat the PRI over not beating it, each is better off by nominating its own candidate. Note that since both parties will appear in the ballot even when they nominate a common candidate (that is, the candidate will appear twice, under both the PPS and the PFCRN label), the disagreement is not about the allocation of proportional representation seats, but about who will win the district (or will have a better chance to win it).

A well-documented possibility is that the (candidate of the) smallest party will give precedence to the larger one: since it is unlikely to win anyway, it is better off withdrawing from the race and facilitating a PRI defeat (Blais and Indridason 2007; Granzier, Pons and Tricaud 2023). That said, this is only possible which of the two opposition parties is the largest one, and both parties and their candidates have an incentive to trump up their chances of winning in order to induce the other to withdraw. Thus, we should observe more opposition coordination in a district when (i) the PRI is more likely to lose; and (ii) the largest FDN party in the district is much larger (in terms of resources, mobilization, or expected electoral support) than the next-largest:

- **H_1.** A FDN coalition will be much more likely when (i) the PRI's level of electoral support is lower; and (ii) the imbalance between the first- and second-largest FDN parties is high.

The consequences of coordination: "mechanical" and "psychological." Paraphrasing Duverger, we can decompose the consequences of electoral coordination into "mechanical" and "psychological." The former stem from the fact that, whenever multiple parties nominated the same candidate in a district, their vote shares would be added up to determine the district's plurality winner. In a

district where, say, the PRI obtained 42% of the vote, the PPS 27% and the PFCRN 22%, the PRI would win if the PPS and the PFCRN presented separate candidates, but would lose if they could agree on a common candidate. For its part, the "psychological" effect of the coalition comes from the fact that voters maybe more inclined to support the FDN –or FDN candidates and brokers more likely to induce voter mobilization– if they expect it can win, and they believe it has a higher chance of winning when it nominates a common candidate. Continuing with the example above, the hypothetical 42-27-22 distribution corresponds to the no-coordination case; when the PPS and PFCRN manage to coordinate, their either drive more voters to the polls or attract voters from other opposition parties so the actual vote distribution ends up being something like 42-29-23. Therefore:

- **H_2.** When a FDN party forms part of a coalition, its electoral support will increase relative a scenario in which it runs alone.

Context: The Mexican 1988 election

The PRI hegemony. Since the late 1920s, Mexican politics was dominated by the Institutional Revolutionary party (PRI after its Spanish initials), an electoral vehicle channeling the ambition and resolving the internal conflicts of the winners of the Mexican Revolution as well as the new political and economic elites created in the wake of it. The PRI held formally competitive elections with clockwise regularity but these were often unfree, and never fair. The party's hold over state resources (Greene 2007), its symbolic legitimacy –it was the party of the revolution– and record of economic performance –it had overseen the Mexican miracles between the 1940s and 1970s (Magaloni 2006)–, as well as its formal or informal cooptation of labor, business, the media and the intellectual class meant that the PRI won all elections that mattered, often by large margins (Simpser 2013). Thus, the regime was sustained less by the use of repression (though it could repress brutally, as with the 1968 student protests) than by the self-fulfilling belief that no ambitious politician ever left the PRI because that meant political death –which in turn meant that all ambitious and capable

politicians would join the PRI, further strengthening its chances. The fact that consecutive reelection was barred for all elected offices further strengthened this logic, as it guaranteed that valuable position would continue to open up regularly (Langston 2006).

It was, as future Nobel Prize Winner Mario Vargas Llosa put it in 1990, "*the perfect dictatorship*." So perfect, indeed, that after the embarrassment of the 1976 election, in which its presidential candidate ran unopposed, the government enacted an electoral reform to entice the opposition to take part in elections. The carrot was an increase in the number of deputies from 237 to 400: the PRI would win almost all 300 single-member district deputies elected by plurality, but opposition parties would gain access to ≈100 proportional representation (PR) seats elected in multi-member constituencies (Molinar Horcasitas and Weldon 2001).[5] Thus, the government would control a supermajority of seats in the lower house, while opposition parties would receive enough perks in terms of legislative offices, appointment contracts, and so on, to entice them to play within the system rather than outside it. In particular, three parties whose names situated them on the nationalist left corner of the political spectrum –the Authentic Party of the Mexican Revolution (PARM); the Popular Socialist Party (PPS); and the Party of the Cardenist Front for National Reconstruction (PFCRN)– acted as the regime's "loyal opposition:" by endorsing the PRI's presidential candidate while running their own candidates for legislative office, they gave a veneer of legitimacy to the system in exchange for some limited access to proportional representation seats.[6]

The 1988 split. With the country unable to honor its foreign debt, the government that assumed in 1982 imposed harsh austerity measures and a program of economic liberalization that sought to dismantle the impost-substitution system that had been associated with the "Mexican miracle." Besides being costly in themselves, these measures went against what the PRI economic policy had

[5]The number of multi-member constituencies increased from 4 in 1982 to 5 in 1985, and in 1988 the number of PR seats doubled to 200. The number of SMDs remained constant at 300.

[6]See Reuter and Robertson (2015) for evidence of similar opposition behavior in Russia.

stood for for decades. Many began to fear (costly, as it turned out) that in 1988 the party would nominate another neoliberal candidate committed to the continuation of the economic reforms. This violated the informal norm according to which outgoing presidents should try to balance the different ideological and political factions within the party (Bruhn 1997, ch. 3). Dissatisfied insiders could made themselves heard, but since nominating his successor was one of the president's major prerogatives (Langston 2006), they had neither formal nor informal channels to participate in the nomination process.

When president de la Madrid chose a neoliberal economist as his successor, Cuahtémoc Cárdenas –former senator (1976-80) and governor of Michoacán (1980-86), as well as the son of president Lázaro Cárdenas, who had nationalized the oil industry in 1938– led a major split from the PRI (Bruhn 1997, ch. 3). Cárdenas's electoral vehicle was the Democratic National Front (henceforth FDN, after its Spanish initials), a coalition with the three "satellite" parties mentioned previously, which also incorporated the Mexican Socialist Party (PMS), a more orthodox left-wing party. While ideological affinity helped, the coalition was mostly a marriage of convenience (Bruhn 1997, ch 4): Cárdenas needed a registered party in order to run; the "satellites," for their part, expected that riding on Cárdenas's coattails would substantially increase their vote share in the legislative election. Between 1979 and 1985, none of these parties had surpassed 3.5% of the national vote, receiving just 10-12 seats in the 400-member Chamber –almost of them PR seats. Backing Cárdenas in the presidential race promised much more than that –including some SMD seats.[7]

Candidate nomination rules further facilitated such an alliance. Specifically, the electoral law contemplated "common candidacies:" if two (or more) parties nominated the same individual for the same office in the same district, all the candidate's votes would be summed for seat-allocation purposes, but *both* parties would appear separately on the ballot. That is, parties backing a common candidate need not lose their identity, and were not forced to enter into a coalition committing them to support the same plank of candidates all over the country: they could back common candidates

[7]Though the PARM had managed to capture two SMD seats in 1985.

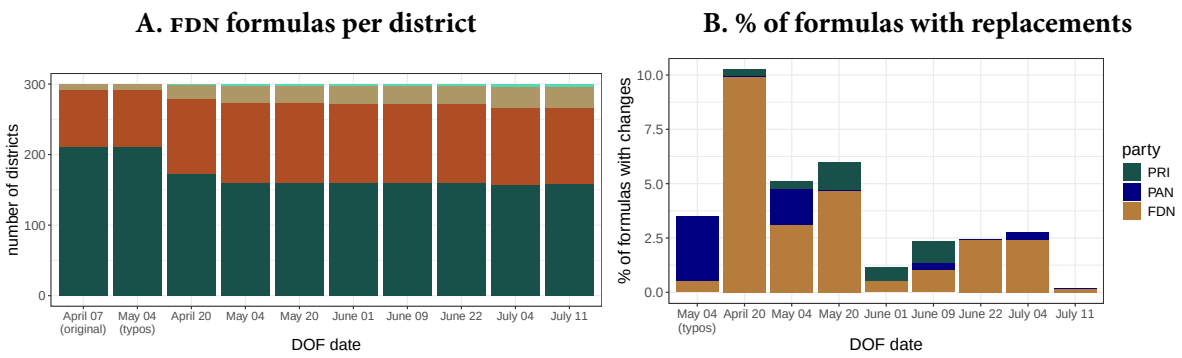


Figure 1: % of replacements and number of FDN formulas by DOF date.

for some offices in some districts but not in others. Even more importantly, common candidacies did not threaten parties' PR votes. Party elites believed, correctly, that supporting a party in the presidential or the SMD ballot would make a voter more likely to support the same party in the PR ballot (Bruhn 1997, ch. 4). Yet precisely because common candidacies allowed all parties to appear in the presidential and SMD ballots, they did not have to worry about disappearing from voters' mind when casting their PR ballots.[8]

In the end, the four parties composing the FDN nominated a common presidential candidate; at least one common candidate in 18 (out of 32) elections for federal senators;[9] and at least one common candidate in 142 (out of 300) single-member districts for federal deputies (see Figure 1A). For PR deputies, each party presented its own candidate list in each of the 5 multi-member districts. Crucially for our purposes, the number of common candidates changed substantially between April 7th, when the full list of candidates was first reported in the official newspaper, and election day on July 6th (see Figure 1B). While these could be due to multiple reasons –death, health issues, second

[8]Assuming that voters did not associate an individual candidate in the SMD race with a specific party –the PARM rather than the PFCRN, say. Given these parties' dismal performance in SMD races in 1979-85, it is safe to assume that the FDN's SMD candidates were mostly unknown to voters.

[9]These were elected by simple plurality in two-member districts whose boundaries coincided with the 31 states plus the Federal District.

thoughts, etc–, the bulk of them were concentrated in SMD candidates nominated by either the PPS or the PFCRN (and sometimes by the PARM as well; the PMS rarely altered its candidate list). This suggests that substantial last-minute negotiations were taking place behind the scenes to facilitate coordination against the PRI.

Data

Candidates. Candidate data comes from Mexico's official newspaper, the *Diario Oficial de la Federación* (DOF).[10] The full list of candidates for president, federal senators and majoritarian deputies was originally published on April 7th, 1988. The data was not in table format, but since it was relatively structured, we exported it to an Excel file using an LLM.[11] The DOF further published a list of typos[12] on May 4th, as well as a list of substitutions and replacements on eight separate dates: April 20th; May 4th; May 20th; June 1st; June 9th; June 22nd; July 4th; and July 11th.[13] For these, the DOF report data on office, district, party ID, original candidate name, and replacement name, but there reason for the replacement is not provided; we only know that a subset of the changes listed on May 4th were coded as "typos," as indeed they were (see fn. 12). We also used an LLM to put these in table

[10] The full list of candidates published on April 7th, 1988 is available here: https://www.dof.gob.mx/nota_to_imagen_fs.php?codnota=4729171&fecha=07/04/1988&cod_diario=203829.

[11] We used a combination of ChatGPT 4, ChatGPT 4o, Claude 3 Sonnet and Claude 3 Opus.

[12] Most of these correspond to misspelled names, though there are also a couple of candidates inscribed in the wrong district (i.e., candidate A replaces candidate B in district #1, whereas candidate B replaced candidate A in district #2).

[13] This last set of replacements took place after the election, but it only comprised three replacements of SMD candidates (plus two PR candidates).

format, harmonized name spellings, and checked that all candidates listed as "replaced" had indeed been nominated at an earlier date.[14]

The structure of the final dataset merits two comments. First, Mexican parties have to nominate not one but two candidates for every position: the principal or main candidate (*candidato propietario*) and a *suplente* or alternate that replaces the principal in case of incapacitation, death, leave of absence, or expulsion from the legislative body. That is, technically parties do not nominate individual candidates but *formulas*, defined as a principal–alternate combination. For convenience, throughout this paper we speak of "formula(s)" or "candidate(s)" indistinctly, but keep in mind but for the votes of two different parties to add up, the entire formula, not just the main candidate, must be identical.[15] Second, the unit of observation is the district-party-formula-DOF date. That is, for every party in every single-member district we have one principal–alternate combination, but since these may change between April 7th and July 11th, we constructed a complete list of candidates for each of 10 DOF dates.[16] When needed, we restrict the sample to a single date and/or group by district-*formula* instead of district-party.

Electoral results. To measure voting intentions, we rely on a public opinion survey of PRI support by state commissioned by newspaper *La Jornada* shortly before the election (Cantú 2019). District-level electoral data for 1982, 1985 and 1988 comes from the Center for the Study of Democracy and Elections (CEDE) at Mexico's Autonomous University–Iztapalapa.[17] Before the establishment of the

[14]The only exception was Alfredo Luna Rodríguez. The June 22nd issue of the DOF lists him as being replaced as *suplente* for the PARM in Michoacán's 7th district. We ignored this change because it is inconsistent with the discussion in the Electoral College and the fact that the FDN won the district.

[15]Indeed, failing to take this into account cost the FDN two seats: DF-40 and Guerrero-09.

[16]The maximum possible number of observations is 300 SMDs $\times$ 8 parties $\times$ 10 dates $=$ 24,000. The actual N is 23,710 because there are 29 instances in which a party fielded no candidate in a district.

[17]"Resultados Diputados," available at https://cede.izt.uam.mx/index.php/estadisticas-electorales-federales/diputaciones/.

Federal Electoral Institute (now National Electoral Institute or INE) in 1990, there is no alternative source of electoral information. That said, we updates the CEDE's numbers in two ways. Shortly after the election the Chamber of Deputies constitutes itself as an "Electoral College" and deliberates on the validity of its members' diplomas. Districts were discussed one by one; many were approved without discussion, but in tens of districts the validity of the elected *priísta*'s diploma was discussed over a series of grueling sessions. Importantly for our purposes, before each district was discussed the total number of votes by party and formula was reported. These were mostly identical to CEDE's numbers, but sometimes there were typos (e.g., a 6 instead of a 9 or a 1 instead of a 7), misspellings (67 instead of 76 or vice versa, etc), or obvious errors (e.g., there was a district in which CEDE messed up the vote total of the PAN's and the PRI's). Whenever this happened, we updated the corresponding values. Second, in some rare cases the opposition's accusations of fraud were convincing enough that the PRI majority acquiesced to annul some precincts and reported alternative vote totals as a results. We also updated these values. Thus, our vote totals are the ones reported in the Electoral College discussions,[18] though note that the difference between these and CEDE's is pretty small: 81.1% of values are identical, and 96.5% (respectively, 98.2%) of the time the difference in vote shares is smaller than 0.5 (respectively, 1.0) percentage points.

Empirical analysis

Descriptive statistics. The 1988 election was the most competitive in Mexican politics in a long time. Table 1 shows that between 1979 and 1991 the PRI won over 96% of SMD in all elections with the exception of 1988, when its take decreased by around 55 seats (18.3% of SMDs). In 1991 it bounced back to its 1985 level, and in 1994 it still won more than 90% of SMDs.

[18] Cámara de Diputados, *Diario de los Debates*, LIV Legislature, August 15th to 31st, 1988. The index is available on https://cronica.diputados.gob.mx/DDebates/54/1er/Ord/index.html.

Table 1: Single-member district seats won by party, 1979–1991

	A. Number of SMD seats						*B. Seat share (%)*					
	1979	1982	1985	1988	1991	1994	1979	1982	1985	1988	1991	1994
PRI	296	299	289	234	289	271	98.7	99.7	96.3	78.0	96.3	90.3
PAN	4	1	9	38	11	22	1.3	0.3	3.0	12.7	3.7	7.3
PARM	0	0	2	NA	0	0	0.0	0.0	0.7	NA	0.0	0.0
FDN/PRD	NA	NA	NA	28	0	7	NA	NA	NA	9.2	0.0	2.3
Total	300	300	300	300	300	300	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0

Source: own elaboration based on the data employed in this paper (for 1988); Wikipedia (for 1979); and Lucardi, Micozzi and Weldon (2025) (for 1982-1985 and 1991-1994).

This short-term setback cannot be understood without the FDN's common candidacies. In Figure 2 we plot the victory margin of the PRI against a hypothetical coalition of all FDN parties in all 300 SMDs. Each dot correspond to a district; those that the FDN *actually* won are in red, while the ones it lost are in green. When the FDN presented a single formula, it won 40% of the time –but there were only five districts with a single FDN candidate. The success rate dropped to a still respectable 31% when there were only two FDN formulas, but the victory rate decreased to 12% and 5% when there were three and four formulas respectively. The last number is particularly galling, as Figure 2 clearly shows that the FDN presented many formulas in districts where its combined vote share greatly surpassed the PRI's.

As shown in Figure 1, the degree of coordination among FDN parties evolved dynamically during the months leading up to the election. When the list of candidates was first released on April 7th, the FDN presented a coalition in 90 of the 300 districts, yet by the time of the election almost half of the districts (142) had at least one common FDN candidate.[19] This was done mostly through candidate replacements: the candidates for one of the FDN's party dropped from the race, and an individual

[19]Since there were four FDN parties, it was theoretically possible to nominate two distinct common candidacies in the same district. This only happened in Michoacán-09, where the same main candidate formed two coalitions with two different *suplentes*.

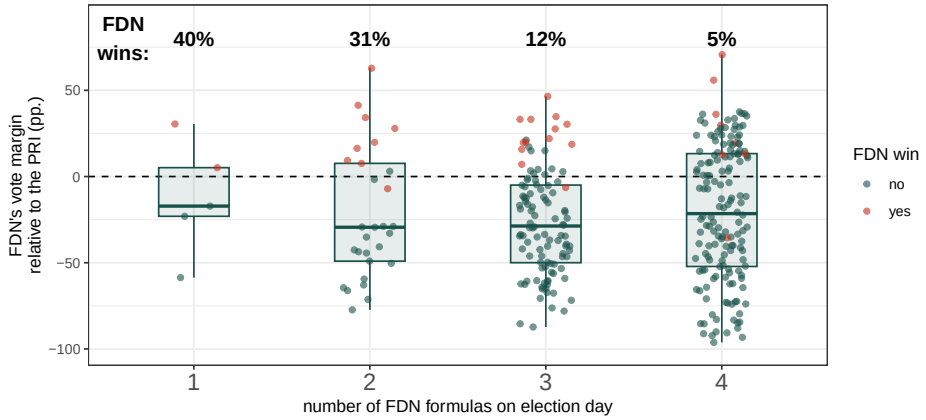


Figure 2: Number of FDN formulas and electoral success. The y-axis shows the victory margin of the PRI against a hypothetical coalition of all four FDN parties, derived from comparing the actual vote percentage for the PRI versus the sum of all individual FDN parties'. Red dots indicate districts where the FDN actually won the election, while green dots denote FDN defeats. Green dots above the zero victory margin represent (perhaps naive) missed coalition opportunities for the FDN.

who was already a candidate for another FDN party replaced him or her.[20] Figure 1A shows that the overwhelming majority of changes were made by the FDN, and the bulk of these took place between April 20th and May 20th. Note that it is possible for a coalition to break down, when a party replaced its formula so it was no longer the same as that of another party's. This this happen, though it was not very common; Appendix Figure A2 shows that this was especially frequent in Chiapas and Yucatán, two states where the FDN finished well behind the PRI.

Coalitions and electoral performance. Besides increasing the FDN's probability of victory by *aggregating* multiple parties' vote totals, coalitions may also improve electoral performance of its individual partners. To see whether this is the case, we follow Hortala-Vallve, Meriläinen and Tukiainen (2024) and estimate a set of difference-in-differences (DID) equations of the form

$$y_{pdt} = \beta \cdot C_{pdt} + \mu_{pd} + \eta_t + \varepsilon_{pdt}, \tag{1}$$

[20] It was also possible for the candidates from two different parties to drop from the race simultaneously, with both parties nominating the same, new set of candidates.

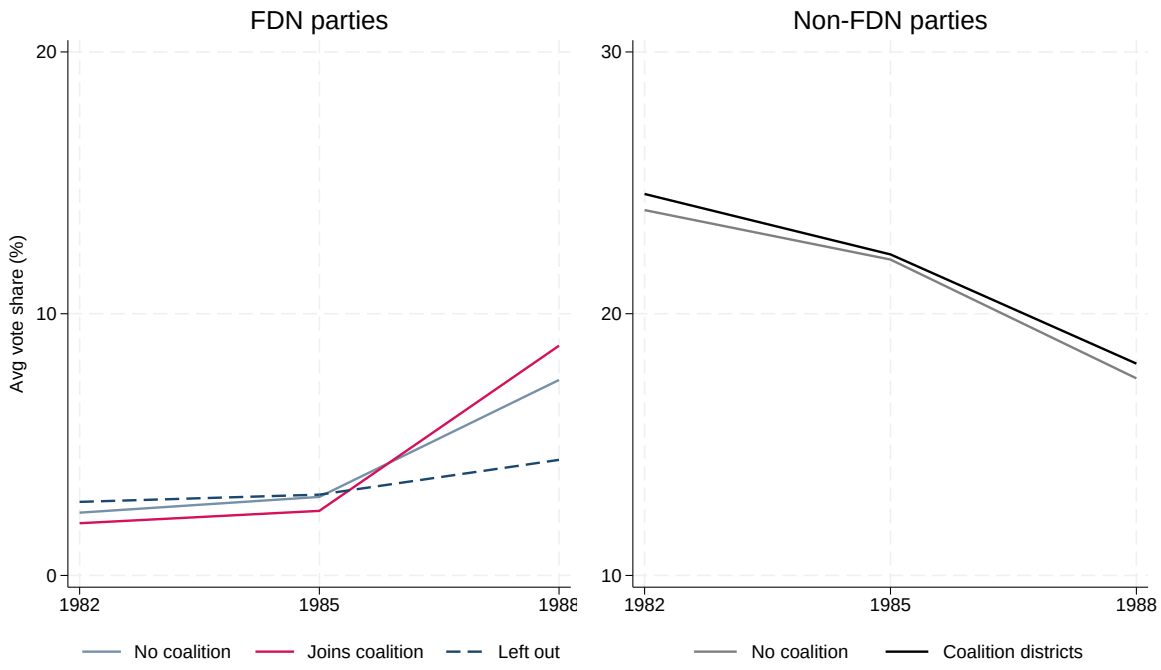


Figure 3: Parallel trends between coalition and non-coalition districts, by FDN membership.

where y_{pdt} is the vote % of party p in district d in election year t. C_{pdt} is a dummy indicating whether party p ran in a coalition in district d in election year t. μ_{pd} and η_t are party-district and election year fixed effects, respectively. Standard errors are clustered by party.

Parallel trends. Our DID identification strategy relies on parallel trends in the individual electoral performance of FDN parties between districts where they join a coalition and the districts where they do not. Figure 3 shows that the trend of electoral performance across coalition and non-coalition districts is identical between 1982 and 1985.[21] Even when we distinguish between FDN parties that were part of a coalition and FDN parties that did not took part of a FDN coalition in a district, the pre-1988 trend is identical for all three groups. The right-hand side of Figure 3 shows the performance for the non-FDN parties. While different in levels, the trend in performance for these parties is also

[21] The initial levels are different, but this is well-handled by the research design.

		PRI VOTE INTENTION				FDN PARTIES			
	Full sample	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	PST/PFCRN	PPS	PARM	PMS
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)
Effect (t=1)	2.72	3.02	3.40**	-0.25	2.73***	-1.36	-0.62	4.86	-0.06
	(1.90)	(3.33)	(1.62)	(1.46)	(0.71)	(1.36)	(0.62)	(4.86)	(0.06)
Placebo (t-1)	-0.01	-0.17	-0.63***	-0.12	-0.12	-0.16	-0.22	0.23	1.34**
	(0.18)	(0.32)	(0.13)	(0.48)	(0.15)	(0.95)	(0.36)	(0.25)	(0.63)
N years	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
N parties	4	4	4	4	4	1	1	1	1
N states	32	8	8	8	8	32	32	32	32
N districts	300	134	80	43	43	300	300	300	300
N obs.	3,600	1,608	960	516	516	900	900	900	900

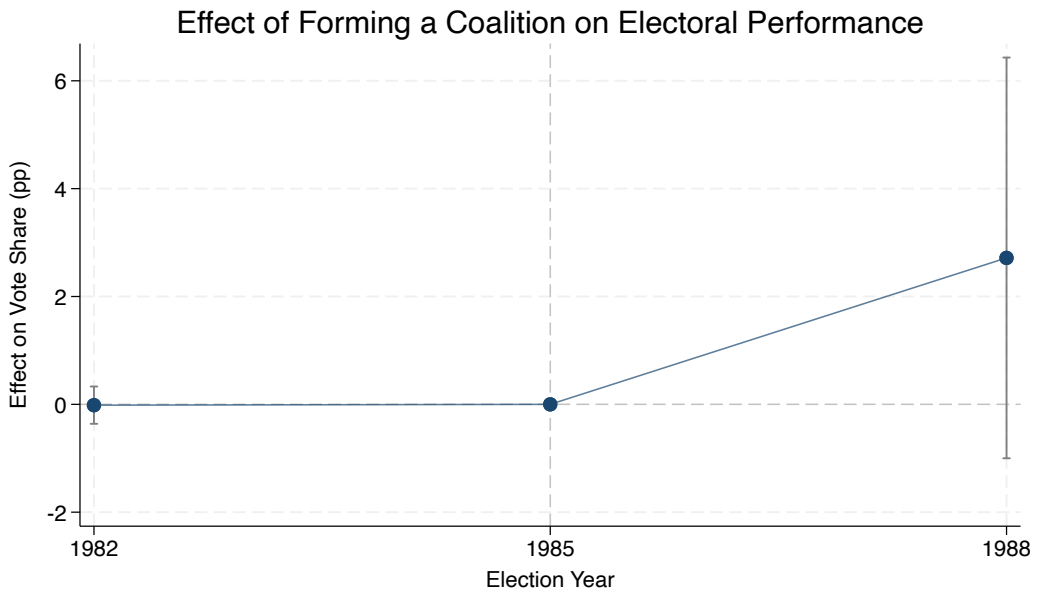
Table 2: DID estimates of the effect of a FDN party forming a coalition on a its vote %. The dependent variable is the individual party's vote %. Column (1) uses the whole set of FDN parties. Columns (2)-(5) divide the 32 Mexican states in quartiles according to the *La Jornada* survey of PRI vote intention. Columns (6)-(9) show the effect for each FDN party separately. Standard errors clustered by party in parentheses.

virtually identical across FDN-coalition districts and the rest. The difference in trends between the two lines is mainly explained by the PRI, as shown in Figure A3.

Main results. The first column of Table 2 presents our baseline DID estimates. Parties forming a coalition increase their electoral support by 2.7 percentage points –a relatively large effect considering that FDN parties obtained just 7.2% of the vote in the average district–, but the estimate is far from significant.[22] In line with the second row of the table, Figure 4 below shows no differences between the pre-trends of party-district combinations that formed a coalition versus those that did not. Recall that since votes were counted first by party and then added up by formulas, our estimates sum up the effect of the coalitions over the vote shares for each party involved and not the overall effect on the votes for the formula as a whole. Given that the vote % of all parties must add up to 100, including all parties in the equation would be misleading. Since across the three election years

[22] Additional results, available upon request, show that if we cluster the standard errors by party-district, the effects do become significant at the 1% level.

Figure 4: Effect of forming a FDN coalition on the vote % of individual FDN parties



we study –1982, 1985 and 1988– only (some) FDN parties formed a coalition, and only in 1988, we only include the four FDN parties in the analysis.

Heterogeneity by PRI strength. While we are interested in coalition synergies between the participating parties, these results could also result from strategic coalition formation. For instance, FDN parties may have selectively formed coalitions in districts where the PRI was already weak, mechanically generating larger observed gains. We therefore assess whether the effects of coalition formation vary depending on the baseline level of PRI support in a survey of presidential vote intention reported by newspaper *La Jornada*, which closely tracks the vote % obtained by the PRI, the FDN and the PAN in each district (see Figure A1 in the Appendix). Although this survey was released shortly before election day, it is plausible that party leaders had access to similar information or political signals about the underlying level of PRI strength, particularly given the strong ties that FDN politicians had maintained until recently (and in some cases still maintained) with the PRI (Bruhn 1997).

The results are shown in columns (2) through (5) of Table 2. The effect is broadly similar –around 2.7-3.0 percentage points– for states located in the first, second or fourth quartiles of PRI support,

but it is only statistically significant for the second and fourth quartiles. This suggests that to the extent that there is an effect, it is not mechanically driven by strategic coalition-making in the PRI's weakest states, but it should be noted that the strongest effect (for the second quartile of PRI suport) is also the only one to show statistically significant evidence of a pre-trend.

Party-specific effects. Columns (6) to (9) show party-specific estimates for each of the FDN's four parties. That is, each column thus show the estimate of the effect of the coalition for each party, in comparison with those districts where no coalition was formed. The only positive estimate is the one for the PARM (4.9 pp.), though it is far from significant; for the other three parties, the estimated effect is negative and insignificant, though close to zero in absolute terms. Taken together, this suggests that to the extent that forming a coalition increased the FDN's electoral chances, it was because the coalition *aggregated* the votes of multiple parties together. Since there was no shortage of districts where the combined FDN vote share was far superior to the PRI's (see Figure 2), this was a winning tactic. At the end of the day, the FDN's main problem was not so much insufficient votes as its inability to nominate enough common candidates in districts that proved to be competitive.

Coalition spillovers. In elections, the vote share gains for one party must be a loss for another. We study spillovers because coalition formation may affect not only the electoral performance of the parties directly involved, but also the broader competitive environment. When opposition parties coordinate, they alter the strategic landscape faced by both voters and rival candidates. Voters may update their beliefs about the formula's platform, strategic voting may intensify, and non-coalition parties may adjust their campaign effort or resource allocation. Ignoring these indirect effects would risk attributing all observed vote shifts to mechanical coordination gains, overlooking general equilibrium responses in multi-party competition.

Moreover, spillovers help us distinguish between pure vote consolidation and genuine electoral mobilization. If coalition gains come primarily from reallocating votes across opposition parties, we should observe negative effects on non-coalition competitors. In contrast, if coalitions expand

			NON-FDN PARTIES				LEFT-OUT FDN PARTIES			
	non-FDN	left-out FDN	PRI	PAN	PDM	PRT	PST/PFCRN	PPS	PARM	PMS
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
Effect (t=1)	0.32	-7.61**	0.39	-0.29	0.84	0.29	0.00	-0.86	-2.08	0.09
	(0.24)	(3.10)	(0.39)	(0.29)	(0.84)	(0.29)	(0.00)	(0.86)	(2.08)	(0.09)
Placebo (t-1)	-0.15	0.87	1.81	-3.12**	0.75**	-0.05	0.56*	0.60*	0.43***	0.36
	(1.14)	(0.76)	(3.53)	(1.39)	(0.30)	(0.04)	(0.32)	(0.34)	(0.16)	(0.45)
Observations	1,198	1,768	300	300	299	299	300	300	300	300

Table 3: DID Estimates of the effect of running against a coalition. The dependent variable is the vote share received by each party. Standard errors are clustered by party. Column (1) estimates the effect for all non-FDN parties. Column (2) shows the effect for FDN parties that are do not join a coalition that was formed in a given district. Columns (3)-(10) split the sample by each party. Pretrends in this case are interpreted as differences in a given party's electoral performance between districts where a coalition was formed and the rest. Standard errors are clustered at the party level across all specifications.

the overall opposition vote, then effects on third parties may be muted or even positive. Examining spillovers, therefore, allows us to understand the mechanism through which coalitions operated and to assess their implications for electoral competition under hegemonic regimes.

Spillover effects. Table 3 reports spillover effects of coalition formation on parties that were not part of the coordinated ticket. Columns (1) and (2) aggregate outcomes for non-FDN parties and for FDN parties that were left out of the coalition in a given district. We find no statistically significant effect on the vote share of non-FDN parties as a group (column 1). In contrast, left-out FDN parties experience a sizable and statistically significant decline in vote share of 7.6 percentage points (column 2). This pattern suggests that coalition gains are not coming at the expense of external competitors, but rather from within the FDN parties themselves.

Disaggregating the non-FDN parties (columns 3–6), we find no evidence of meaningful spillovers onto the PRI or the PAN. The point estimates are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero, indicating that coalition formation among FDN parties did not systematically erode the vote share of the PRI nor that of the main opposition alternative, the PAN. Looking at the pre-trends for the subsamples of parties outside the FDN, we find evidence that the performance of these parties was

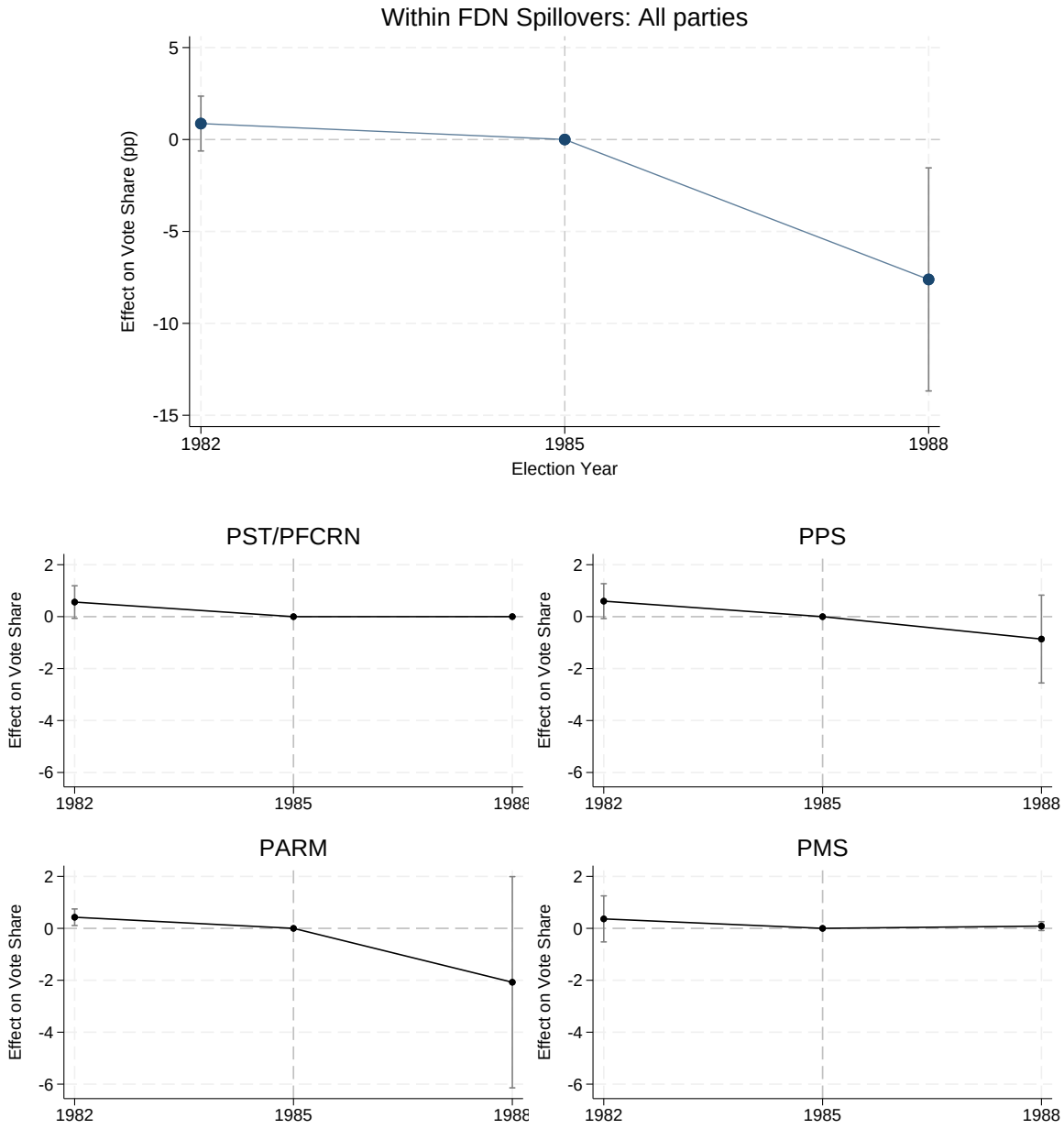


Figure 5: Spillover of FDN coalition over left-out FDN parties

determinant in the formation of FDN coalitions. In particular, the results indicate that the PAN underperformed by 3.12 percentage points in the average district where a coalition was formed. We see an opposite reaction to the PDM vote share, and no differences in the performance of the PRI nor the PRT between districts where a coalition was formed and the rest.

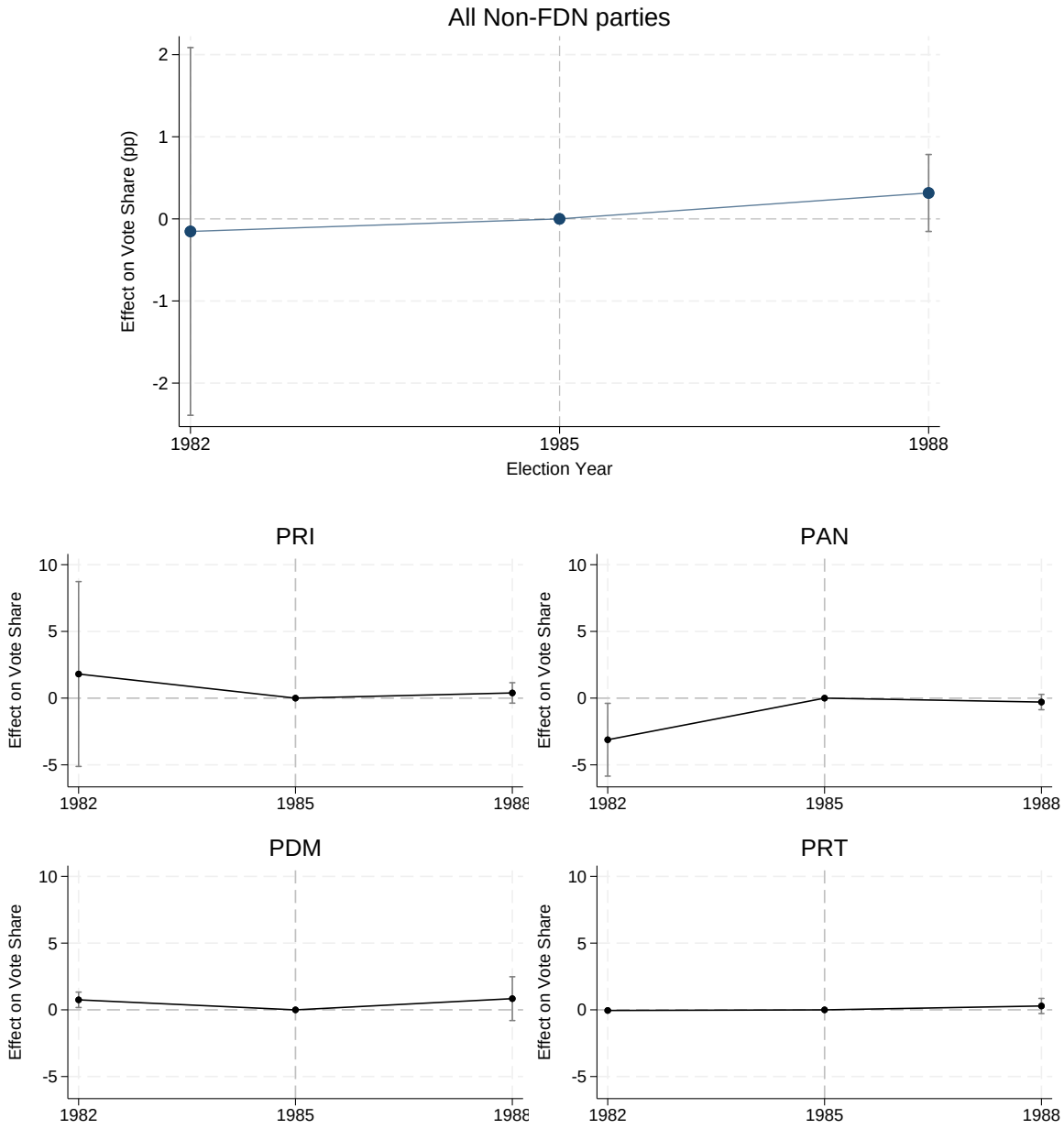


Figure 6: Spillover effects on non-FDN parties using de Chaisemartin and D'Haultfoeuille (forthcoming). This piece of evidence suggests that FDN coalitions were more likely to form in districts where the PAN underperformed and where the PDM overperformed in the 1982 election.

Columns 7 to 10 disaggregate the spillover effects for each FDN party. From this perspective, the pre-trends are indicative of whether the electoral performance in the 1982 election was indicative of whether the party in question would join the coalition that was eventually formed. We observe a

slightly positive pre-trend for three out of the four FDN parties. Taken together, this is evidence that parties fail to correctly anticipate the gains from a coalition in districts where they have previously performed slightly better. Figures 6 and 5 below show the event study-like version of our results.

The negative effect on left-out FDN parties is also visible when we examine them individually (columns 7–10), though estimates are imprecise for some of the smallest parties. Taken together, the evidence is consistent with vote consolidation within the FDN coalition: when some parties coordinate, they attract votes that would otherwise have gone to their co-ideological partners running separately. Importantly, placebo estimates in the pre-treatment period are generally small and do not display a systematic pattern, lending support to the parallel trends assumption. Overall, the spillover analysis indicates that coalition gains largely reflect within-bloc reallocation rather than broader shifts in the electoral balance across major parties.

Conclusion

This paper provides direct evidence on how and when opposition parties coordinate in an authoritarian regime, and what such coordination accomplishes electorally. Leveraging unique institutional features of Mexico's 1988 election and newly digitized nomination data from the *Diario Oficial de la Federación*, we observe elite coordination decisions as they unfolded throughout the election calendar. The repeated amendments to candidate lists allow us to move beyond ex post vote distributions and instead measure coordination at the moment it was chosen. This approach enables us to disentangle two distinct mechanisms emphasized since Duverger: a mechanical effect that aggregates votes across parties presenting a common candidate, and a "prychological" effect that alters parties' individual electoral performance.

Our results show that coordination was neither automatic nor uniform. It expanded substantially during the campaign, suggesting that parties updated their beliefs and renegotiated candidacies as new information became available. Consistent with a simple coordination framework, com-

mon candidacies were more likely in districts where the PRI was expected to be vulnerable. These patterns underscore that even in authoritarian settings –where electoral manipulation, repression, and patronage loom large– elite actors respond to strategic incentives in ways that resemble coordination dynamics in democratic systems.

Electorally, coordination mattered. The mechanical aggregation of votes across allied parties reversed the outcome in 18 districts. At the same time, difference-in-differences estimates indicate that coalition participation increased a party's vote share by roughly 2–3 percentage points on average, though these gains primarily reflected consolidation within the opposition bloc rather than vote losses for the PRI or other external competitors. Spillover analyses confirm that left-out coalition partners bore the main cost, experiencing substantial vote declines. Thus, coordination reshaped legislative representation largely by reallocating votes within the opposition and by converting fragmented support into seat-winning pluralities.

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Online Appendix

"Opposition Coordination in Authoritarian Regimes"
(for online publication only)

A Descriptive statistics

La Jornada survey

Figure A1 shows that the *La Jornada* survey, which measured the PRI's presidential vote intention at the *state* level, is highly predictive of the district-level vote % obtained by the PRI's, the FDN and the PAN in the election for the Chamber of Deputies.

FDN coordination and electoral support by state

Figure A2 shows (a) the FDN's level of coordination by state and DOF date, as measured by the average number of formulas per district; and (b) the FDN's electoral performance in the state, defined as the average combined vote % of the FDN parties in the state's districts.

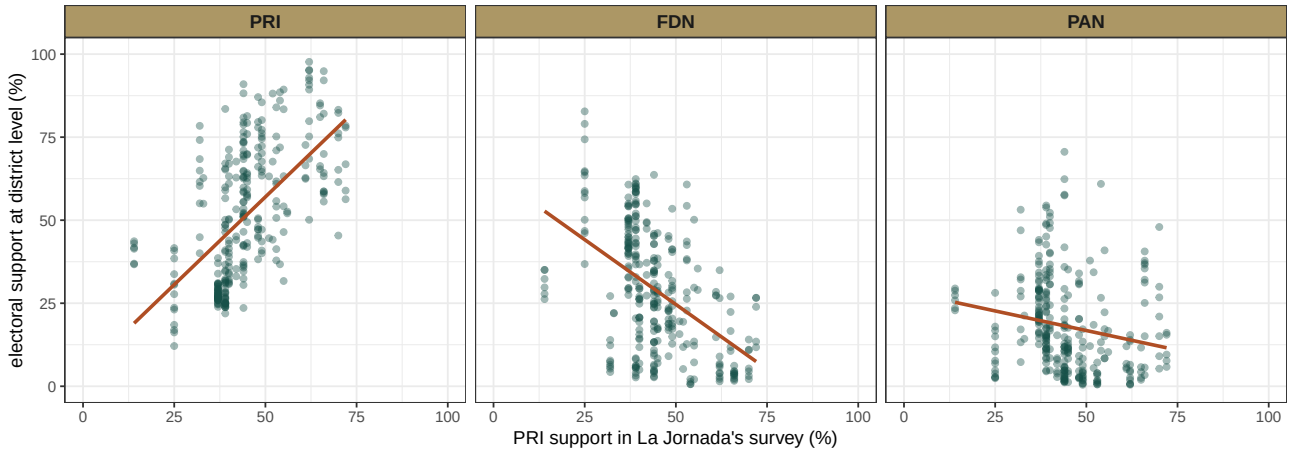

Figure A1: Expected PRI presidential vote % according to *La Jornada*'s survey (by state) and % of SMD vote for each major party (by district). Note that the FDN's values report the added vote percentage % of all FDN parties together.

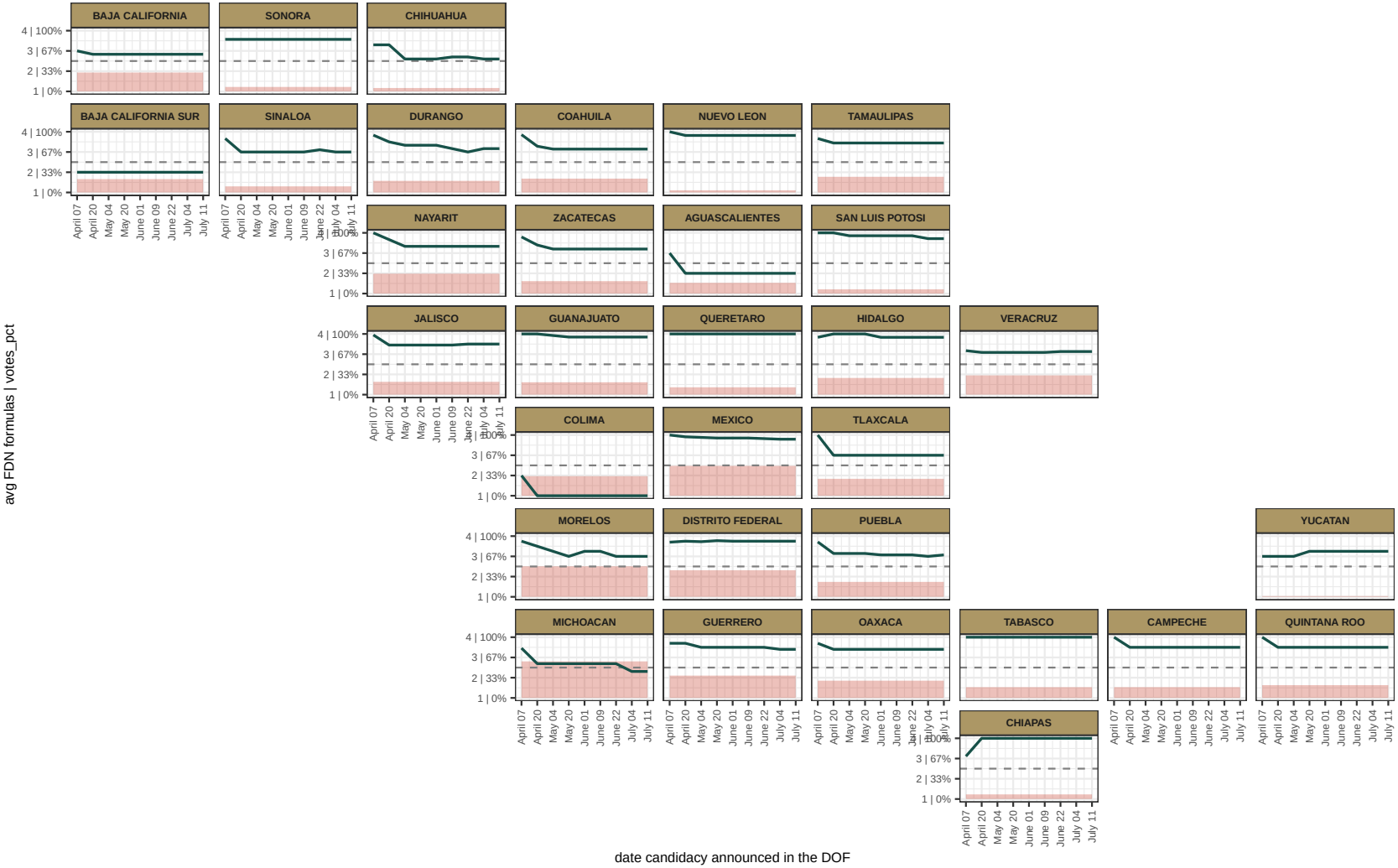

Figure A2: Average number of FDN formulas by state and DOF date. The shaded red area shows the average aggregated FDN vote % in the state's SMDs. The broken horizontal line indicates the 50% mark.

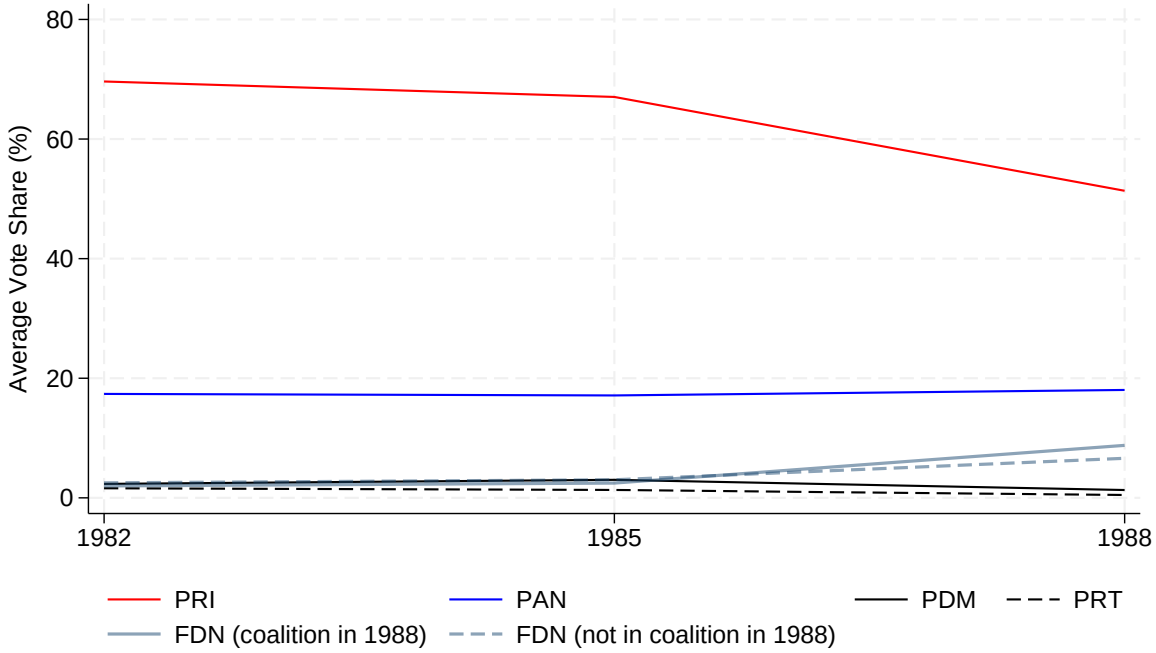

Figure A3: Vote trends for the non-FDN parties